

Building a Case File

You have read the rules. You have run the sample case — or at least read through it. Now you want to build your own. Good. The process is not complicated, but it is specific. A Neon Relic case is not a story you write in advance and then reveal to the players. It is a situation you construct out of interconnected pieces, set in motion, and manage as it deteriorates.

This guide walks through the process from first concept to a finished case file package ready for the table. Each step tells you which template file to open, which fields to fill in, and what to think about as you work. By the end, you will have a complete set of documents — printed, organized, and ready to play.

If you want to skip the methodical approach and build something fast, the [Case File Generator Tables](#) in Chapter 15 can get you to a playable case in fifteen minutes.

Before You Start

Gather the blank template files from the starter kit. You will use these throughout the process:

Template	What You Will Use It For
<code>case-brief-da.html</code>	Your mystery statement, the real situation, containment truths, resolution notes — the DA's master reference.
<code>case-brief-player.html</code>	The briefing you hand to the players — only what the Covenant would share with field agents.
<code>operations-board.html</code>	The single tracking surface for the case — shift row, organization rows, milestones.
<code>organization-reference.html</code>	Detailed milestone descriptions for each organization, including cross-link consequences.
<code>relic-sheet.html</code>	Full artifact profile — tier, category, effects, fracture table, containment truths.
<code>location-page.html</code>	One per location. The document in front of you when players arrive somewhere.
<code>npc-card.html</code>	One per significant NPC. Pull these alongside location pages during play.
<code>information-card.html</code>	One per discoverable fact. Double-sided — player front, DA back.

Open all of these now, or at least have them accessible. You will move between them as you work.

Step 1: Choose Your Artifact

Every case begins with a relic. Open the **Relic Sheet** ([relic-sheet.html](#)) and start filling it in.

You do not need the complete artifact profile yet — just enough to anchor the case. Decide these three things:

- **What is it?** Not its cosmic significance, but its mundane form. A cassette tape. A surgical instrument. A pocket watch. A spearhead in a wooden shaft. The more ordinary it looks, the more unsettling it becomes when its nature emerges.
- **What does it do?** Pick one core behavior. A wound relic reopens injuries. A sovereignty relic imprints command-language. A surveillance relic broadcasts to anyone who knows how to listen. This behavior will flavor every entity in the case.
- **What makes it worse?** Think about what the artifact responds to. Handling? Blood? Claims of divine authority? Movement between custodians? This becomes the **trigger** — one of the three Containment Truths the agents must discover.

Fill in the Relic Sheet's name, tier, category, and the Activation Condition and Containment Truths sections as far as you can. You will return to refine this as the case takes shape.

Step 2: Write the Mystery Statement

Open the **Case Brief — DA** ([case-brief-da.html](#)). The first field on the form is the **Mystery Statement** — a single sentence that captures the entire situation.

A good mystery statement answers: *What happened, what is still happening, and what will happen if the agents fail?*

Examples:

- *"A stolen spearhead with sovereignty properties has destabilized a black-market handoff and is pulling multiple factions toward one contaminated chain-of-custody crisis."*
- *"A radio receiver modified with 1943 ESP components is broadcasting parallel-timeline transmissions from a university lab, and a journalist's story will go to press in 48 hours."*

If you cannot fit it in one sentence, the case is too diffuse. Simplify until you can.

Write it in the Mystery Statement field on the DA Case Brief. Then fill in the **Real Situation** field below it — a paragraph or two explaining what is actually happening, who is really involved, and how the case can be resolved.

Step 3: Define the Containment Truths

Still on the **Case Brief — DA** ([case-brief-da.html](#)), fill in the **Containment Truths Summary** section. Every relic has three essential facts the agents must discover for a safe recovery:

- **Trigger** — What makes the artifact more active or dangerous? What should the agents avoid doing?
- **Appetite** — What does the artifact feed on, amplify, or attract? What kind of behavior, emotion, or energy makes it stronger?
- **Quiescence** — What conditions make it safe to handle? What materials, rituals, or environmental factors suppress the artifact's effects?

Write these in clear, specific terms. "The Spear becomes more active when moved repeatedly between custodians" is useful. "The Spear is dangerous" is not.

These three truths will become **Information Cards** later — the most critical cards in the case, each requiring multiple discovery paths to ensure the agents can always find them.

Step 4: Build the Operations Board

Open the **Operations Board** ([operations-board.html](#)). This is the backbone of the case — the single surface where you track time, organization pressure, and relic escalation.

The Shift Row

The top row of the board is already formatted with 14 day-columns, each quartered into four shifts. During play, you will fill in quadrants as shifts pass. For now, decide where the **relic milestones** fall.

Relic milestones are keyed to specific day numbers. When the last shift of a milestone day is filled, the artifact event triggers. Write your milestone descriptions in the DA Case Brief under the **Relic Milestones** section, keyed to day numbers:

- **Day 11:** Early signs — subtle physical symptoms, environmental glitches, the first hint that something is wrong.
- **Day 8:** Escalation — the artifact's behavior is now affecting people who are not in direct contact with it.
- **Day 5:** Crisis point — the artifact is actively dangerous. Public effects are becoming difficult to conceal.
- **Day 2:** Endgame — the artifact is reaching its final state. Bearer selection, activation sequence, or dimensional breach is imminent.
- **Day 1:** Catastrophe — the worst-case outcome plays out.

You do not need exactly five milestones. Scale to your case. A short case might have three; a long

campaign arc might have seven.

Organization Rows

Below the shift row, add a row for each organization in the case. Each row needs:

- A **name** — who or what this organization is.
- A **starting value** — how many squares remain before their catastrophe. Higher means more time; lower means more immediate pressure.
- **Milestone squares** — specific points on the countdown where something happens, labeled with O#M# shorthand (O1M1, O1M2, etc.).

Stagger the starting values. If every organization starts at the same number, they will all hit their milestones at the same time, which turns varied pressure into a single overwhelming beat. Give the most urgent organization a starting value of 5 or 6. Give the slowest one 11 or 12.

Write the **milestone descriptions** in the Organization Reference document (see the next step).

Step 5: Flesh Out the Organizations

Open the **Organization Reference** (<organization-reference.html>). For each organization on the Operations Board, create an entry with:

- The organization's O# identifier and name
- Whether it starts **active** or **dormant** (dormant organizations activate through triggers you will write into other milestones)
- Each milestone's O#M# label and description — including what happens narratively and what happens mechanically (which other organization rows advance, what Locations change, what NPCs appear or disappear)

The milestone descriptions are where you write the **cross-links** — the connections between organizations that make the case feel alive. When the wounded thief surfaces at the clinic (O2M2), it should advance the police and the Compact because a visible thief attracts both institutional and criminal attention. Write that directly into the milestone text:

O2M2: The surviving thief surfaces at the illicit clinic with wound bloom. Advance O3 (Police) by 2 squares. Advance O1 (Compact) by 1 square. L5 (Illicit Clinic) becomes available.

Aim for four to six active organizations in a standard case, with zero to two dormant organizations that activate through play. More than eight total rows is difficult to track during a session.

Step 6: Create the Case Entities

This is where the case takes shape as a playable experience. You will create three types of documents: Location pages, NPC Cards, and Information Cards. These three entity types are the building blocks of every scene in the case.

Locations

Open a blank **Location Page** ([location-page.html](#)) for each location in the case. A standard case has five to seven locations. For each one, fill in:

- **Name** — The estate. The police station. The church archive. The currency exchange. The clinic. Keep them concrete and evocative.
- **Description** — What the agents see when they arrive. Write this as if you are reading it aloud at the table.
- **Availability** — How the location becomes accessible. Use one of the standard keywords: **open** (available from the start), **clue-locked** (requires specific information), **contact-locked** (requires NPC introduction), **time-locked** (opens on a specific day), or **packet-locked** (unlocked by a Covenant packet return).
- **NPCs Present** — Who is here, and how that changes at milestones.
- **Information Available** — Which Information Card IDs (I#) can be discovered here.
- **Organizations Present** — Which organizations have interest here (O# shorthand).
- **Positive / Negative Results** — What happens if the scene goes well or badly.
- **Milestone Changes** — How the location changes when organization milestones fire.

Make sure at least one location is **open** at case start. Always give the agents somewhere to go.

NPC Cards

Open a blank **NPC Card** ([npc-card.html](#)) for each significant NPC. A standard case has six to eight NPCs. For each one, fill in:

- **Name and Organization** — Who they are and who they work for (O# shorthand).
- **Secret** — What they are hiding from the agents. Not necessarily sinister — a priest might be hiding that his order has already sent a recovery team.
- **Goal** — What they are actively trying to accomplish during the case. If an NPC has no active agenda, they are an information dispenser. Give them a goal or cut them.
- **Artifact Connection** — How they encountered the relic and what effect proximity has had on them.
- **Starting Knowledge / Gained Knowledge** — Which Information Cards (I#) they know at case start, and which they gain at specific milestones.
- **Locations** — Where they can be found.

- **Positive / Negative Results** — What they give if approached well, what goes wrong if approached badly.

Information Cards

Open a blank **Information Card** ([information-card.html](#)) for each discoverable fact. A standard case has fifteen to twenty-five Information Cards. For each one, fill in:

- **ID** — I1, I2, I3, and so on.
- **Content** — What the agents learn. Write this on the player-facing side.
- **Found At** — Which Locations (L#) where this can be discovered.
- **Known By** — Which NPCs know this.
- **HQ Fallback** — What day HQ can provide this if the agents miss it in the field. Leave blank only for supporting intel that is not critical.
- **Type** — **Containment Truth** or **supporting intel**.

After creating all three entity types, cross-check them:

- Every **Found At** reference on an Information Card must point to a real Location. Every **Known By** must point to a real NPC.
- Every NPC's **Locations** field must match a Location's **NPCs Present** field.
- Every Location's **Information Available** must match Information Cards' **Found At** entries.
- Every Containment Truth must have at least **two field sources** (Locations and NPCs) plus an **HQ Fallback**.

THE DEAD END TEST

For every Containment Truth, ask: *If the agents never visit one source, can they still learn this?*
If no, add another source or assign an earlier HQ Fallback day.

Step 7: Write the Player Briefing

Open the **Case Brief — Player** ([case-brief-player.html](#)). This is what you hand to the players at the start of the session.

The **Player Case Brief** contains only what the Covenant would share with field agents: the case name, region, objectives, known actors, starting leads, and operational parameters. No secrets, no Containment Truths, no milestone details.

Write it in the Covenant's institutional voice — brisk, factual, slightly formal, and carefully redacted. The players should feel like they are reading a classified briefing, not a game summary.

Step 8: Final Assembly

Gather everything you have created:

Document	Status
Case Brief — DA	Mystery statement, real situation, containment truths, relic milestones, resolution notes, DA pacing guidance.
Case Brief — Player	Covenant agent briefing — case name, region, objectives, known organizations, NPC dossiers, starting leads, operational parameters, regional contacts.
Operations Board	Shift row with relic milestones, organization rows with starting values and milestone squares.
Organization Reference	All organizations, each with O#M# milestone descriptions and cross-link consequences.
Relic Sheet	Full artifact profile, fracture table, containment truth checklist.
Location Pages	One per location, cross-linked to NPCs and Information Cards.
NPC Cards	One per NPC, cross-linked to Locations and Information Cards.
Information Cards	One per discoverable fact, cross-linked to Locations and NPCs.

The Solvability Checklist

Before you run the case, verify:

- ☐ Every Containment Truth has at least two field sources (Locations + NPCs) plus an HQ fallback.
- ☐ No single Location is mandatory for forward progress.
- ☐ Every Location reveals information, unlocks an NPC or route, or worsens the situation in an informative way.
- ☐ At least one actionable option is visible at the start of each shift.
- ☐ A failed scene produces movement, not dead air.
- ☐ The Mystery Statement fits in one sentence.
- ☐ Each organization has player-facing signs before it becomes a crisis.
- ☐ Each NPC has a secret, a goal, and an artifact connection.

If all of that checks out, print the package, organize it in a folder, and sit down at the table. The case is ready.

Cross-References

Full case file rules

[Chapter 15: The Case File](#)

Sample case (The Spear That Went Dark)	Chapter 20: Sample Case File
DA guidance and running toolkit	Chapter 14: Director of Agents Guidance
Artifact tiers and containment profiles	Chapter 11: Artifacts of Power and Doom
Case generator tables	Chapter 15: Case File Generator Tables